or simply aboriginals or tribals. Now classified for official purposes as Scheduled Tribes, they are now increasingly referred to as Adivasi, or ‘first people’ – as they will be here.

These two non-Sanskrit peoples, Dravidian and Adivasi, are very much the chief focus of this book, but be warned that what I have written is partial in both senses of that word: partial in that it is incomplete, and partial in only considering aspects of South Indian history that I find particularly intriguing.

The structure of my book is roughly chronological, in that I begin with prehistory and end in India in the twenty-first century, but in between I have hopped about a bit. I have written mostly about the Dravidian South but I have included parts of the middle ground between the two major language groups. This includes what was the ancient pre-Sanskrit kingdom of Kalinga but became Orissa and is now Odisha State, where Odiya (formerly Oriya) is the predominant language. Although part of the Indo-Aryan language group and so quite distinct from the Dravidian group, Odiya is derived from the spoken Prakrit of Eastern India, which is the primary language of the earliest written Jain texts, suggesting that it came with early Jain immigrants from the North and overwhelmed the many local tribal Munda languages then being spoken. I have also made a brief diversion into what was for centuries Maratha country and is now Maharashtra, chiefly so that I can enlarge on that important but still largely unknown ruling dynasty the Satavahanas.

I have also found it impossible to ignore early historical events north of the Narmada boundary wall-and-ditch. One cannot consider the impact of Brahminical culture on South India without writing about the Arya and where they came from – which in turn means at least touching on that extraordinary and still barely understood culture that preceded the Arya, initially called the Indus Civilisation, then the Harappan Civilisation and now, in some circles (but not